

There is a reason that Formula 1 is often referred to as the 'pinnacle of motorsport'. Thanks to the changes in regulations and innovations in technology over the past several decades, F1 cars have seen some design and technology improvements that would put many modern cars to shame. While some of these designs and developments caught steam and are still seen in modern-day cars in some way, shape, or form, others were quickly contested by teams and their designers and were dropped by the teams as quickly as they were adopted. Here we will have a look at some such technological innovations that did not land well with the teams.



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BRAWN DOUBLE DIFFUSER

Ever heard of the story of an underdog coming with a solution to a problem in a sport and clinching the title out of nowhere? Well, if not, then you'd like to explore the story of the Brawn F1 team and their double diffuser design using which they raced to a double championship in 2009. Formula 1 was in the nascent stages of entering the turbo hybrid era, which would be dominated by Brawn's successor, Mercedes AMG F1 team. The foundations of this domination was laid when the Brawn team designed their car with a double diffuser design for the 2009 season. While other teams had been using a traditional design which had only a single deck of airflow channels, Brawn's design had something different. The engineers had added an additional duct to increase the airflow and create a double decker design, allowing the team to regain some of the lost 50 per cent downforce due to the regulation changes. Other teams protested this design but the FIA deemed it legal and the rest is history.



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THE FAN CAR

If there was one F1 car that would be a definite contender for the most absurd design award, then it would be the Brabham BT46B driven by Niki Lauda in the year 1978 during the race in Sweden. This time, it was the brain of Gordon Murray doing the trick. This was another example of a team battling to get the most of the now legal, ground effect. What the additional fan did was increase the downforce on the car by a substantial margin when it raced around the track, giving it more grip around the track, especially the corners. The results were instant as the car went on to win the only Grand Prix it ever raced in. The teams again were quick to protest, with Colin Chapman leading the charge. Legend has it that a combination of teams' outrage and political pressure resulted in the car being outlawed immediately.